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The End of (Objective) Leisure

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ABSTRACT
This paper examines the ontological and epistemological assumptions about leisure to critically assess the state of leisure scholarship. It argues that there are no intrinsic characteristics or essences inherent to leisure, and that researchers ought to make an important distinction between leisure as socially constructed social facts, and the erroneous view of leisure as an ontologically objective and universal entity. It is purported that from an epistemological standpoint the crisis of leisure sciences has never been resolved; however, the absence of a stable theory is an opportunity for new forms of research and knowledge to emerge. The article introduces postleisure as a departure from leisure-objectivism and a shift towards plural readings of leisure, which may find sufficient backbone in Rorty's notion of epistemological solidarity.

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Introduction

What can we say objectively about leisure? Does it really exist? Is it a universal phenomenon or something that has been produced socially within societies? Is there an essence to leisure or is it simply a matter of conceptual 'framing'? Are there intrinsic characteristics one can observe among all human beings? And are there more epistemologically privileged varieties of leisure that tell us accurately what it is? These questions are the epicenter of leisure scholarship: they guide, both implicitly and explicitly, knowledge about leisure. However, they can also leave devastating footprints in the field, as too much disagreement and incompatible theoretical frameworks can undermine leisure sciences and lead to crises of epistemic legitimacy, representation, meaning, and identity.

The purpose of this paper, therefore, is to examine the ontological and epistemological assumptions about leisure – namely, the question of whether leisure can be deemed an objective phenomenon resulting in objective knowledge. Some academics, such as Spracklen (2017) hold that "rational theories of leisure take it as evident that we can identify and isolate leisure, that we can know what the purpose of leisure is in the wider world" (p. 226). Others, however, have disagreed, and argued instead for more fluid and pluralistic approaches to the study of leisure (e.g., Blackshaw, 2017; Coalter, 1997; Henderson, 2006, 2010). As indicated in the title of this paper, the view taken here is in support of the latter: it is argued that universalist approaches to leisure – or

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leisure objectivism – detached from culture and social settings, are unattainable, and that future rejuvenations of the field will rest on more flexible alternatives.

The manuscript is structured in three sections. The first part examines the meta-epistemology and ontology of leisure, and explores in what capacity leisure exists and how it is possible to have varieties of leisure that are epistemologically objective but also ontologically relative. The second part outlines the key problems with leisure theory, leading to a discussion on the de-centered and postmodern understandings of leisure. The final part introduces and articulates *postleisure* as an approach in which the loss of objectivism can be replaced with plural accounts of leisure and a shift towards *epistemological solidarity*.

Meta-epistemology and ontology of leisure

The philosophico-theoretical approach taken in this paper is underpinned by a conceptual and epistemological meta-analysis, including the objects, subjects, and methods of leisure sciences. Similarly to meta-ethics being "primarily concerned with analyzing the concepts fundamental to ethical discourse," meta-epistemology is interested in "analyzing the concepts fundamental to epistemological discourse" (Fumerton, 1995, p. 1). In light of this outline, we can say that meta-epistemological questions of leisure are then those primarily concerned with the analysis of the concepts of leisure. In other words, a meta-epistemology of leisure occurs when we examine the dominant views, prevailing theoretical perspectives, and core assumptions. It is an effort to take stock of the ways in which knowledge of leisure has been produced, and the field at large constituted. Put yet in other words, the meta-epistemology [of leisure] is the "theory of the theory of knowledge [of leisure]" (Kyriacou, 2017, para. 1).

Because theories are built around ontologies – whether these are social ontologies/social realities or broader questions of being, becoming, and existence – it is important to also discuss ontological matters. Epistemology and ontology are intertwined in that a view of leisure as an objective phenomenon traceable to all human beings and societies (ontology), for example, becomes the necessary condition for objective knowledge of leisure (epistemology). Accordingly, a researcher fueled by objectivism may seek to verify leisure in different contexts. Vice versa, a view of leisure as a relative phenomenon can only yield knowledge of leisure bound to the parameters within which it emerged/was studied. The latter can transpire as plural, and at times incommensurable, understandings of leisure. These philosophical and methodological concerns are often poorly understood, which can lead to confusion about the kind of claims made about leisure. While this paper focuses mainly on epistemological questions, it is fruitful for the project ahead to begin by thinking about how to approach leisure ontologically.

In what capacity does leisure exist?

Metaphysical and ontological questions about leisure are not often addressed in the literature; nonetheless, they are fundamental to consider. One reason is that they can guide research and the ways in which findings are presented; another is that they can create paradigmatic mayhem and lead to vague notions about leisure if not addressed

carefully. We shall only focus on selected examples to illustrate what this means, namely the kind of discourse that comes into play when pondering leisure at the level of ontology and metaphysics.

Perhaps the most well-known metaphysical notion of leisure was put forth by a German Catholic philosopher, Josef Pieper (1952/2009). He presented leisure in theological terms as a profound state of being, describing it as "an attitude of mind, a condition of the soul" (p. 40). According to Pieper, leisure is something that is only possible "when a man [sic] is at one with himself, when he acquiesces in his own being, whereas the essence of *acedia*[1] is the refusal to acquiesce in one's own being" (p. 40). Furthermore, "leisure is a receptive attitude of mind, a contemplative attitude, and it is not only the occasion but also the capacity for steeping oneself in the whole of creation" (p. 41).

All we need to say about Pieper's interpretation of leisure for the purposes of this article,[2] is that it falls in the category of beliefs (as opposed to facts). It differs qualitatively in that it is a proposition that is impossible to assess scientifically through research. In other words, one would have to accept this assertion without being able to tackle it empirically, as there are no facts, evidence or methods with which to evaluate it. In addition, it is not easily compatible with other contemporary understandings of leisure, and in this regard, we are explicitly cautioned not to contrast it with non-activity or even tranquility. In Pieper's (1952/2009) words: "leisure, it must be clearly understood, is a mental and spiritual attitude—it is not simply the result of external factors, it is not the inevitable result of spare time, a holiday, a week-end or a vacation" (p. 40). And so, leisure through the eyes of Pieper is a state of contemplation or "philosophizing" (see pp. 61–125 on *The Philosophical Act*).

A more thought-provoking proposition is Pieper's suggestion that leisure precedes culture; i.e., that "culture depends for its very existence on leisure" (Pieper, 1952/2009, p. 17). This claim has previously been addressed by Rojek (in Blackshaw, 2012), who counter-argued that leisure is the cultural phenomenon. The stance taken in this paper similarly argues that the way we organize ourselves socially – including our ability to invent or have a notion of 'free time,' 'work,' 'holidays,' 'the weekend,' etc. – is a social and cultural process. Therefore, it is culture that precedes leisure (and other social phenomena constructed by humans), and not the other way round. Indeed, it would be challenging for scientists to empirically account for leisure existing *a priori*.

[1]The term *acedia* is generally used to describe idleness, not caring, apathy, sloth, etc. *Acedia* is employed by Pieper (1952/2009) specifically to juxtapose leisure as a contemplative and spiritual attitude. In his words: "metaphysically and theologically, the notion of acedia means that a man does not, in the last resort, give the consent of his will to his own being; that beneath the dynamic activity of his existence, he is still not at one with himself; that, as the Middle Ages expressed it, sadness overwhelms him when he is confronted with the divine goodness immanent in himself (that sadness which is the *tristitia saeculi* of Holy Scripture)" (pp. 38–39).

[2]This section on Pieper was expanded at the request of one of the reviewers and is thus larger than originally intended. For the sake of further elucidation on this matter, it may be useful for the readers to know that the view of the reviewer was that Pieper saw leisure as a way of contemplating one's place in, or relationship to, the cosmos, and overall, deserves more recognition. However, the stance taken in this paper is that any theological notions of leisure are ideologies based on spiritual beliefs, which cannot be traced or verified. They are thus a different variety altogether. Although spiritual and theological views about leisure may be interesting, they are not in any way ontologically or epistemologically privileged. To reiterate the point made in this article, leisure is a social construct created by human beings in different social settings – its existence depends on interacting agents (as opposed to, say, rocks and trees, whose existence does not depend on interacting agents).

Leisure has also been understood as a type of 'essence' or 'entity' that exists outside the realm of interacting human beings. Inspired by the writings of Durkheim, Caillois (1959/2001) in his work *Man and the Sacred* made a distinction between the sacred as something greater than humans, and the profane as everyday existence or 'the ordinary.' Festivals and rituals are given as examples of how human beings have connected with the sacred. However, here too, it is important to make a distinction between metaphysical and theological declarations about leisure, and the study of leisure as social facts (i.e., as something created by socializing humans). Specifically, one has to be careful not to confuse the work of ethnographers, anthropologists, historians, sociologists, and so forth – whose tasks have been to understand the social realities of different social groups – with metaphysical claims about leisure. Although it is possible to have facts about the role of festivals in a given society or a cultural setting, it is a different claim altogether to purport that such phenomena are examples of leisure as something transcendental.

The key point is that when we ponder the question *In what capacity does leisure exist?* there are no ontologically privileged philosophical and theological renderings over and above social facts. As this is still a very murky and misunderstood domain not only in leisure studies but also in other fields, the following section attempts to elucidate how social facts are constructed, and how it is possible to have something called 'leisure.' By doing so, we will turn our attention from broader metaphysical and ontological claims about leisure to social ontology or social reality – in which leisure can and does manifest.

How is leisure possible?

The field of social ontology is concerned with understanding the social world. It does not deal with the existence of physical objects observable in nature (e.g., rocks and trees), but with the kind of realities that are constituted socially and culturally. Leisure is the outcome of the latter, because it does not exist independent of our minds. To answer the question, *How is leisure possible?*, social constructionism is therefore invaluable as a philosophical tool, because it accounts for the manifestations of leisure as social facts constructed by humans. The additional value of social constructionism is its ability to explain postmodern and pluralist accounts of leisure in philosophical terms, and thereby assist with addressing the ontological and epistemological uncertainties that may be facing novice researchers.

John Searle (1996, 2010) has painstakingly worked out the elements needed to explain social reality; the purpose here is to fleetingly address some of them. Social reality is made up of social facts, which are the outcome of beliefs and intentions. Hence, a tourist, the Euro, a holiday, and a boarding pass are all social facts that have been created socially (as opposed to natural processes). For social facts to exist, they require two or more individuals to agree, recognize and ascribe meaning to objects, experiences, people, and places, which implies collective agreements (also known as *intentionality*) and the functions these perform (also known as *status functions*). Status function is a term

[3]Readers may find useful one reviewer's spotlight on the mistranslation of Pieper's original work (1948), *Musse und Kult* and *Was heisst Philosophieren?* (for more information, see Lewis, 1973).

designated to capture the meaning assigned to objects, experiences, people, and places. Status functions typically carry *deontic powers* – entailing the kind of duties, obligations, and permissions that are attached to them. This way, a piece of paper – we understand and accept to be a boarding pass – gives one the right to board an aircraft and travel to another 'destination.' There is nothing special about a piece of paper with some ink on it, unless it is collectively recognized as a boarding pass. The deontic power is what elevates a social fact to an *institutional fact*. Put very simply, institutional facts are social facts that have deontic powers; one can tell an institutional fact from a mere social fact by studying whether there is any deontology attached to the social fact and if it is collectively accepted. For example, a boarding pass created as part of a game among children would still count as a social fact but would not constitute an institutional fact. On the other hand, a boarding pass issued by an airline is considered an institutional fact because it allows a person to board an airplane and be transported to another country. What is imperative to emphasize, is that meaning is shared among people through language and symbols, which are necessary for establishing deontic powers. A final but no less important term Searle introduces to explain social reality is *brute facts*. Brute facts designate the material objects and things that exist in the external world. Accordingly, airplanes and boarding passes are not mere hallucinations, but institutional facts created from physical material (which exists external to, and independent of, our mind). To better comprehend this vocabulary and understand how humans construct social reality, it is valuable to read Searle (1996, 2006, 2010) and Pernecky (2012, 2014, 2016) for field-specific insights.

In light of the above clarification, one can study the construction of leisure as 'free time' – conceptually and semantically reflected, for example, in German (freizeit), Polish (wolny czas), Czech (volný čas), Slovak (volný čas), and other languages. The study of leisure-as-free-time in West Germany in the 1980s will produce knowledge about the kind of institutional facts that determined leisure within this context. Likewise, leisure in communist Czechoslovakia or USSR in the 1970s may yield a more nuanced set of institutional facts and deontic powers, such as restricted travel to Western countries, the influence of Marxism, communist ideals reflected in the consumption of leisure, the creation of 'bony' (special vouchers) and 'Tuzex' (a chain of currency shops; see Bren, 2012), and so forth. These accounts of leisure, however, will be different from a tribal community living in a remote part of the world, where the concepts of 'free time' and 'leisure' may not exist/be represented and may be replaced with different social and institutional facts altogether. This multiplicity can be expressed as follows:

$$\text{Leisure} = (\text{L1} = \text{France}_{1300\text{s}};\ \text{L2} = \text{United Kingdom}_{1840\text{s}};\ \text{L3} = \text{Czechoslovakia}_{1970\text{s}};$$

$$\text{L4} = \text{India}_{1900\text{s}};\ \text{L5} = \text{leisure} - \text{at} - \text{work};\ \text{L6} = \text{serious leisure};\ \text{L7} = \text{artful living};$$

$$\text{L8} \ldots\ \text{Ln})$$

Hypothetically speaking, the conception of leisure as 'free time' can be tied to any historical period and, indeed, researchers have observed (some will say imposed) leisure in many cultures and epochs. Because leisure has been defined as many things, in addition to leisure-as-free-time, there is an array of other conceptual frames which provide for additional interpretations of leisure, including: 'leisure-at-work' (Duerden,

Courtright, & Widmer, 2018); Stebbins' (2015a) concept of 'serious leisure'; and Bouwer and van Leeuwen's (2013) depiction of leisure studies as 'artful living'; etc. In this regard, *Ln* in the formula above signifies an indeterminate number of ways in which leisure can be framed and understood.

To return to the question of whether or not objective knowledge of leisure is achievable, the answer is a little convoluted. According to Searle (2010), we are presented with the possibility of obtaining objective knowledge of ontologically relative social facts (i.e., L1, L2, L3). To put this in less technical terms, it means that it is possible to have epistemologically objective knowledge of leisure-as-free-time (volný čas) in communist Czechoslovakia, despite it being ontologically relative (i.e., it was created by, as opposed to existed outside of, human minds). Hence, what can be determined are the institutional facts and deontic powers in terms of duties, responsibilities, obligations, rights, and so forth. These are not imagined; these were constituted socially and culturally, and we can have objective knowledge about them. However, all social and institutional facts are bound by context (i.e., L1, L2, L3, etc.) and, in some instances, not commensurable. And therefore, there can never be objective knowledge of leisure as something universal – a common entity or an essence that can be isolated and observed across all cultures. The implications are that L1, L2, L3… Ln cannot be conveniently added up and neither can they be reduced to a simple statement.

Dealing with epistemologically objective but ontologically relative social facts

The strategies to, as well as tensions surrounding, epistemic objectivism about social facts are best depicted by some varieties of pragmatism and realism. Although it is beyond the capacity of this paper to address these in depth, it is important to emphasize that pragmatism represents a range of thinkers, some of whom would raise objections to *any* notion of objectivism. Here, we may consider a pragmatist continuum with the philosophers Hilary Putnam on one end – renowned for his work in the realm of realism – and Richard Rorty on the other – aligned with anti-foundationalist and anti-essentialist philosophy. Putnam, whom we can brand as a weaker realist, worked towards developing an approach that would bridge the gap between scientific realism and relativism, called *internal realism* (also *pluralistic realism* and *pragmatic realism*; see Case, 2001; Pernecky, 2016). Whereas Putnam would be more likely to accommodate Searle's epistemological objectivism and therefore *truth* within context, Rorty would reject any suggestion of truth and call it an illusion. With Rorty, we find that there is no escape from arriving at an abyss of interpretation and reinterpretation, which undermines the possibility of epistemic objectivism. To Rorty, interpretations can be *useful*, but never *true*. In his words:

> Objects are not 'more objectively' described in any vocabulary than in any other. Vocabularies are useful or useless, good or bad, helpful or misleading, sensitive or coarse, and so on; but they are not 'more objective' or 'less objective' nor more or less 'scientific.' (Rorty, 1982, p. 203)

Accordingly, leisure as L1 in our formula can be a useful instrument in some circumstances but not necessarily in others, and not always compatible or commensurable with L3, L4, and so forth. Thus, those researchers aligned with the views of Rorty may

concur that it would be a mistake to think that we are accumulating or making progress towards better or more epistemologically robust knowledge of leisure. Instead, L1, L2 … Ln are acts in pluralism: they are numerous conceptual and representational schemes. The criteria for 'finding' leisure are often selected and agreed upon by academics; there are no other standards or accurate measures one can appeal to in order to obtain an objective notion of leisure. In this regard, much of postmodern scholarship, discussed next, is underpinned by the movement away from objectivism and the need to establish a true account of leisure.

To summarize, in contrast to Searle and Putnam, the type of pragmatism and pluralism advocated by Rorty is an utter exodus from 'truth' and a move to something he sees as 'epistemological solidarity.' We will return to this notion in the final part in an attempt to articulate postleisure and to explore what this might mean for future leisure scholarship. As we conclude this section, it is important to reiterate that relative and plural understandings of leisure differ from universalist views of leisure (i.e., leisure-objectivism). Objectivism is commonly adopted in positivist, and to some extent postpositivist, approaches (see, for example, Veal, 2018), and can exhibit itself through attempts to elevate one theoretical framework as more accurate or true (e.g., Stebbins's notion of a Serious Leisure Perspective presented as "a truly integrated, theoretic perspective"; 2015b, p. 53). On the other hand, postmodern and post-postmodern scholars have replaced truth with *pragmatic utility*. In order to fully grasp the implications for the field, the following section looks at the epistemological and methodological drawbacks that have undermined the science of leisure.

The unresolved problems of leisure theory

From an historical perspective, leisure has been studied within different historical periods as far back as Ancient Rome and Greece (Garland, 2008; Golden, 1998; Toner, 1995), and observed in cultures like Islam, Byzantium, Japan, China, and India (Spracklen, 2011). It has also been found in the Mediaeval period where it is associated with storytelling, board games, going to fairs, drinking with friends, bear baiting, and religious feasts, and for the noble class also tournaments, hunting, and chess (Polack & Kania, 2015). European urban leisure in the 1700 s included social activities such as visiting museums, theaters, concerts, opera performances, and art exhibitions; spending time at sea-side resorts, restaurants and coffee houses; walking and promenading; and sports (Borsay & Furnée, 2015). Some inquiries into leisure have focused more specifically on the Industrial Revolution as a point in time where leisure industries increased with the rise of working class and commercialized forms of leisure (Borsay & Furnée, 2015; Cunningham, 2016). Leisure occupied a distinct period of time in modernity (Crawford & Blackshaw, 2009) and continues to be studied and debated in the context of post-industrial and postmodern societies (e.g., Gershuny, 2003; Hannigan, 1998; Rojek, 1995, 2009; Veal, 2019; Wagg & Bramham, 2016).

Such a reading of leisure gives a strong sense of permanence. In fact, it almost appears as if we have always had, and always will have, leisure. Problems arise, however, when we probe into how leisure is constituted – i.e., when we scrutinize the criteria that ought to tell us consistently and with certainty when we do or do not have 'leisure.'

We have already established that the phenomenon of leisure, through a social constructionist lens, has been conceptualized in manifold ways (recall L1, L2, L3 … Ln) and interconnected with a host of concepts. In fact, there are too many for these to be noted here, but texts such as *The SAGE Dictionary of Leisure Studies* (Blackshaw & Crawford, 2009), the *Routledge Handbook of Leisure Studies* (Blackshaw, 2013), *A Handbook of Leisure Studies* (Rojek, Shaw, & Veal, 2006), and Harris's (2005) *Key Concepts in Leisure Studies* offer a window into the diverse ways in which leisure has been made sense of.

The philosophical and theoretical issues surrounding leisure have been known and debated for several decades. For instance, Giddens in his essay on play and leisure commented on the "conceptual confusion and ambiguity in the use of the key terms 'leisure,' 'play' and 'recreation'" as far back as 1964 (p. 81). Among those articulating the problem in the 1980s were Gunter and Gunter (1980), who observed two extremes: on the one side were those academics ready to "accept without question even the most simplistic notion of leisure, their ranks swollen by the ready availability of the operational definition in social science" (p. 361), and on the other were those asserting that leisure was too complex, too diverse, and too subjective for modern science to deal with. In philosophical terms, their analysis loosely describes the views of the objectivists and the wide array of anti-objectivists.

The definitional and theoretical difficulties facing leisure scholars had to do with consistently articulating what was being investigated. In order to study leisure, leisure had to be isolated and given precise conceptual parameters. Without these, the field at large would become theoretically flippant. The reason is easily understood: if there is more than one framework, and if these are not compatible, then what ensues are multiple understandings that do not necessarily add up to a single coherent theory (of leisure). However, leisure was defined as a number of things: as a specific variety of time, as a state of mind, as an opportunity to exercise and engage in given activities, as a state of passivity, as an expression of will, and as a combination of these variables (Gunter & Gunter, 1980). In short, the crisis of leisure was marked by conceptual and theoretical inconsistencies, and has been addressed in several contributions (e.g., Burton, 1996; Hemingway, 1990, 1995; Henderson, 1991; Jackson & Burton, 1989; Kelly & Kelly, 1994; Lynch, 1997; Pritchard, 2006; Rowe, 2002; Schor, 2006). Coalter (1997, p. 255), in particular, commented on the "relative failure to develop an understanding of the societal, cultural, and individual meanings associated with leisure." Drawing on the work of Roberts (1987), who had previously suggested that there is no such thing as British leisure theory, he added that there was also "an absence of a dominant methodological paradigm of the sort that characterizes leisure sciences" (Coalter, 1997, p. 256). Worth highlighting, too, are the views of Henderson – a reader and a member of the editorial advisory board for the journal *Leisure Studies* – who has voiced that a "'definition' of leisure remains problematic not only for researchers but also for social understanding" (Henderson, 2006, p. 392), and that "an open-ended definition allows interpretations about the meanings of leisure socioculturally as well as contextually" (p. 392). To paraphrase what this has meant for the field: there is no agreed definition of the phenomenon called 'leisure'; there are only different ways in which leisure can be framed, and open interpretations as to what it may entail.

The crisis of leisure was interconnected with the so-called 'crisis of representation,' reverberating through the social sciences and humanities towards the end of the 20th century. Its main claim was that social researchers were "unable to directly represent or depict the lived experiences of the people they study" (Smith, 2004, p. 962) and therefore posed a challenge to the positivist and strong-realist approaches. Underpinned by such uncertainties, objectivity, truth, and validity, too, became questioned. Anthropologists especially were sensitive to matters of methodological inadequacy in describing social reality (Marcus & Fischer, 1999), with Rosenau explaining that "the problem is fundamental in such a field, where so much depends on accurate description, on some degree of correspondence between what the scholar finds and what 'is really out there'" (Rosenau, 1992, p. 106). Inevitably, these concerns became immensely problematic also in leisure scholarship.

Rojek's (1995) work titled *Decentering Leisure* irreparably destabilized the field. In this paradigmatically disruptive text, we find that the common-sense approaches to leisure and the association of leisure with freedom, choice, and life-satisfaction are inadequate. Leisure is compared to utopia and described as "one place on the map of the human world where we are constantly trying to land, but which perpetually evades our reach" (p. 1). Leisure studies, Rojek argues, is discursive in character and less about "the examination of integrally constituted physical space or 'natural' segmented time and 'free' experience" (p. 1). Moreover, with the disappearance of authenticity and the liquefaction of fixed referentials, "there is no longer any basis for leisure as a distinctive area of life" (p. 9). Rojek's ideas do not need any further introduction for they are well known among readers about leisure. What is important to highlight, however, is that with leisure irreversibly decentered, any universal or objectivist views of leisure have been pushed out of the picture as well. In this regard, the end of objective leisure – only expounded and re-affirmed in this article – arrived with postmodernism towards the end of the last century. In the words of Rosenau (1992):

> The very act of comparing, in an effort to uncover similarities and differences, is a meaningless activity because postmodern epistemology holds it impossible ever to define adequately the elements to be contrasted or likened. (p. 105)

Although the crisis of leisure was exacerbated by the challenges of postmodernism and the crisis of representation, these pivotal moments are not necessarily seen as an obstacle. The absence of a stable theory is an opportunity for new forms of research and knowledge(s) to emerge and, to some extent, signals intellectual liberation (Baert, 2005). Some thinkers, such as as Blackshaw (2017), describe 'the end of leisure' as a reason to celebrate "because leisure had at last been liberated from the tyranny of Leisure Studies, both *for individuals* and *for itself*" (p. 17).

In the age of 'post-'

Rojek describes postmodernism as a "tendency in thought and practice to recognize fragmentation, flow and the collapse of authoritative power hierarchies based in class, masculinity and race" (Rojek, 2005, p. 19). He adds that "it has led leisure researchers and professionals to consider how individuals are situated in relation to power and scarcity in the context of globalization and detraditionalization" (p. 19). However, Rojek is

also careful to assert that "this is very different from claiming that the condition of postmodernity has fully arrived" (p. 19). This cautionary statement is important, for it would be foolish to expect postmodernism to arrive as a large tsunami wave, sweeping across entire nations all at once. Yet it is also necessary to recognize that postmodernity works in a rhizomatic fashion, and so we must think, instead, of pockets and eruptions.

We can already see the raptures of *post-postmodernism* and a shift towards empowered, active, and more involved individuals mobilized by new technologies (Nealon, 2012). In Vermeulen and van den Akker (2010) description of *metamodernism*, we are told to be in a "both-neither" dynamic: "at once modern and postmodern and neither of them" (p. 6). Hence, it is increasingly difficult to articulate one's existential locale, for we are simultaneously occupying multiple plateaus. As the authors state: "the metamodern is constituted by the tension, no, the double-bind, of a modern desire for *sens* and a postmodern doubt about the sense of it all" (p. 6). We are also simultaneously entering an age of *digimodernism*, described by Kirby as the "modulated continuity of postmodernism" (Kirby, 2009, p. 2), and we, too, have arrived at the shores of *postcapitalism* (Mason, 2015). The crucial point is that none of these are ferocious invasions but outbursts operating in an elusive fashion. The subtlety with which they take place is underscored, for example, by Mason's conviction that capitalism "will be abolished by creating something more dynamic that exists, at first, almost unseen within the old system, but which breaks through, reshaping the economy around new values, behaviours and norms" (Mason, 2015, p. ix). What this amounts to is a sense of fluidity which makes it impossible to fix space and bound time, as advocated by Bauman in *Liquid Modernity* (2000). In his words:

> Fluids travel easily. They 'flow', 'spill', 'run out', 'splash', 'pour over', 'leak', 'flood', 'spray', 'drip', 'seep', 'ooze'; unlike solids, they are not easily stopped – they pass around some obstacles, dissolve some others and bore or soak their way through others still. (p. 2)

The implications for the study of leisure are that it will be ever so difficult to clutch on to any objective ideals, which are too narrow to facilitate the kind of understandings needed to tackle the complexity heralded above. In this regard, Coalter (1997) was much softer in stating that postmodernism accentuated the gaps in leisure studies. Over two decades later, it has become evident that postmodernism has been far more disruptive: leisure is no longer a stable entity; it has been shaken-up too vigorously by postmodern scholarship for it to be glued back into the simple shapes in which it was once represented.

Postleisure

Objectivist approaches amount to leisure being presumed, expected, and accepted as innately part of human life. When leisure is taken as an objective entity or a phenomenon with unique properties that can be isolated and measured, then the task of researchers is to produce objective knowledge of it. In this paper, such an approach has been termed *leisure-objectivism*. It has been counter-argued, however, that if leisure is conceptualized and understood as many things, then objective knowledge of leisure is not possible. What develops instead, is knowledge of phenomena that is relative to certain *relativizers* or reference frames, such as paradigms, systems of beliefs, practices, and

activities (for further explanation of relativism in science, see Nola, 1988). The epistemic limitations rise to the fore once we realize that leisure sciences – i.e., the key concepts and theoretical frameworks upon which they have been built – are relative and incommensurable.

Arriving at this point begs the following questions: if the concurrent epistemological framings of leisure are limited and perhaps even inadequate to understand postmodern existence, what, then, are the implications for the study of leisure? If leisure is not an objective entity reliably 'found' across all human beings, cultures, and societies regardless of historical periods, conceptual scaffolds, and socio-cultural practices, what remains to be said about leisure? If we are to concur with the points laid down so far and accept that there is no essence, no intrinsic characteristics, no leisure phenomena without humans taking part in the constructions, then there is an urgent need to re-think the aims and goals of future leisure scholarship. Moreover, if leisure is liquefied and decentered, then whatever may follow in the form of postleisure ought to be sufficiently flexible to grapple with the shifting modes of being and doing, and re-aligned with a different set of epistemic standards.

Among the viable alternatives available is repositioning 'leisure' and focusing on its relational attributes. In this respect, it may be inevitable to embrace the paradigm of complexity (see Morin, 1992, 1995), and focus not so much on studying the fixed entities conceptually preconceived as 'leisure' but e*mergent phenomena* and their relational dynamics; this implies the acceptance of uncertainty as part of postleisure discourse. With regard to novel approaches to knowledge, among the intellectual movements to have recently emerged and that are worthy of noting is postdisciplinarity (see, for example, Coles, Hall, & Duval, 2005, 2006; Hollinshead, 2010; Munar, Pernecky, & Feighery, 2016; Pernecky, 2019). Postdisciplinary scholarship encourages more flexible views of leisure without strict adherence to a dominant conceptual grammar. Although the interests of postdisciplinary thinkers are too broad to discuss in-depth in this article, researchers may be drawn to one of the four emerging strands: (1) complexity driven approaches; (2) critical, emancipatory, equitable, and transformatory *knowledge acts*; (3) post-existentialism; and (4) disciplinary deviance and disobedience (see Pernecky, 2019).

As far as re-adjusting to a different set of epistemological standards, Rorty's (1991) notion of epistemological solidarity, discussed next, can be a fertile measure of success – allowing us to replace the need for veracity and reliability.

Postleisure as 'epistemological solidarity'

The departure from leisure-objectivism and the acceptance of leisure-pluralism opens up new spaces for communication and exploration – not in order to 'confirm' or reduce leisure with rationalist precision to something detached from the subjective and intersubjective states of interacting humans, but as an effort to understand leisure in terms of its relational propensity. Whereas the need for objectivity implies distance and independence from any human activity and interference, the shift to solidarity is typified by those who Rorty calls, as we have already established, 'pragmatists.' These are thinkers who:

> … see the gap between truth and justification not as something to be bridged by isolating a natural and transcultural sort of rationality which can be used to criticize certain cultures and praise others, but simply as the gap between the actual good and the possible better. (Rorty, 1991, p. 22)

Furthermore, with the demise of objectivism, there is no need for 'truth'; as explained by Rorty:

> … the pragmatist does not have a theory of truth, much less a relativistic one. As a partisan of solidarity, his account of the value of cooperative human inquiry has only an ethical base, not an epistemological or metaphysical one. Not having *any* epistemology, *a fortiori* he does not have a relativistic one. (p. 24)

Of course, the pragmatism envisaged by Rorty is of a specific variety, and to this end, it has been shown that there are other versions available. Importantly, the epistemological solidarity proposed here centers on relational approaches – extending to planetary and ecological solidarity, economical solidarity, Indigenous solidarity, and overall need to engage in dialog, collaboration, and cooperation vis-à-vis leisure discourse. Thus conceived, leisure vocabularies can become more-or-less *useful* (as well as detrimental, oppressive, and destructive when assessed critically) in making contributions to communities around the world. Epistemological solidarity, then, is one way of replacing leisure-objectivism with pluralism – with multiple, contrasting and at times competing ideas about humans' existence.

In the concluding remarks of "Producing the Crisis: The State of Leisure Studies," Rowe (2002) called for openness about what comprises leisure and leisure studies, but also noted that if there is no agreement as to what constitutes the phenomenon of leisure – and with Rojek (1995) decentering its founding premises – the future of the field may lead to a "relativist abyss" with "everything potentially becoming leisure" (p. 11). This paper has argued that there is no way out of leisure-as-many-things and therefore relative and plural readings of leisure. Crucially, it would be incorrect to reduce relativism to the dismissive variety of 'anything goes' slogans that fail to acknowledge that there are many shades and forms of relativism. More importantly, there is value in studying what 'goes' and for whom, under what circumstances or within which contexts. Postleisure as a relational perspicuity asks that researchers embrace the multiplicity and complexity of emergent phenomena. Thus, rather than saving leisure from falling into a relativist abyss, the call is for researchers to start mapping the terrains. In this regard, the mindset of thinkers who may be interested in postleisure is not as much compelled by disciplinary duty (i.e., conform to the established views about what leisure ought to constitute according to agreed-upon norms and frameworks, and the need to 'save' the phenomenon), as it is by exploring the variety and richness that manifest vis-à-vis leisure-as-many-things.

In addressing the problems of 'truth,' 'validity,' and 'reliability,' such ideals are replaced with degrees of usefulness, because what 'works' in one context may not 'work' in another. To appeal to epistemological solidarity, and to argue that pluralism is not a matter of 'anything goes,' is to adopt different criteria altogether. Namely, what 'goes' or does 'not go' can be evaluated by means of moral and ethical concerns. Caton (2012), for example, has proposed substituting objectivism with moral reasoning – a shift from 'truth' to contemplating 'consequences'. These approaches to leisure and tourism

scholarship are fundamentally relational, because they strive to examine the extent to which the social realities that emerge vis-à-vis leisure are just, equitable, and ethical.

There are yet other incentives for departing from leisure-objectivism. These come in three inter-related parts and are articulated persuasively by the French philosopher Edgar Morin. First, "we should abandon the Promethean dream of dominating the universe and aspire instead to live together on earth" (Morin, 1995, p. 8). If this vision becomes the focus of postleisure scholarship, then the future of the field is imbued with immense dialogical and relational potential. Why? Because the most pivotal question becomes: *How can we be together (through leisure) with different values, norms, traditions and appearances?* Second, we ought to conceive of postleisure as being part of a larger project that strives to civilize the Earth; in the words of Morin (1995): "this means not only creating a confederation of humanity, while respecting existing cultures and homelands, but also promoting democracy and solidarity" (p. 9). Most scholars will concur that the global challenge ahead lies in fostering diversity and recognizing the views and interests of different populations. To this end, to speak of (epistemological) solidarity is not a utopist dream but a necessity in the 21st century marked by complexity. On this note, Morin, thirdly, reminds us that "as to solidarity, a society cannot increase in complexity without an accompanying increase in solidarity, since more complexity means more freedoms, more opportunities for initiative and more possibilities of disorder, which can be both fruitful and destructive" (Morin, 1995, p. 10).

Conclusion

Leisure sciences represent researchers from a wide range of disciplines, who have made an important contribution to what has become a distinct branch of the social sciences. Yet the foundations upon which it continues to build knowledge are not as stable as some may have hoped. The results of the meta-epistemological and ontological examination of leisure can be summarized into three key points: (1) the end of objective leisure means that there is no 'leisure' as an ontologically independent entity that 'holds' at all times and for all peoples outside of reference frames; and that (2) we therefore cannot have reliable knowledge of leisure as something universal. Rather, leisure is construed intersubjectively by communities, regimes, societies, and academics, which means that (3) we have access only to knowledge of context-specific varieties of leisure.

The observed onset of post-postmodernism, digimodernism, metamodernism, liquid modernity, and postcapitalism all amount to the realizations that the old ways of being and doing are shifting; that technology is radically altering how we communicate, participate, learn, and work; and that through increased virtual mobility, we have instant access to ideas, knowledge, markets, places, people, and experiences. This century, more than any previous period, will offer increased opportunities to work from home and play at work, manage time according to personal needs, and provide more freedom, flexibility, and personal fulfillment. It is here that the objectivist ideals and dichotomous approaches to accurately locating 'leisure' are likely to fall short of facilitating any profound knowledge, because we cannot proclaim with certainty whether a person who is fully immersed in a passionate activity is engaged in work, fun, leisure or something else altogether.

The end of objective leisure is a call for new ways of thinking about leisure, including the criteria for evaluation. In this regard, this article has accentuated the theoretical pitfalls entrenched in leisure scholarship, and offered postleisure and epistemological solidarity as an alternative to leisure-objectivism. It has been proposed that the shift to postleisure is underpinned by complexity and solidarity: leisure is not detached but deeply interwoven with other social and natural phenomena as well as global problems, and there are many ways in which leisure can be articulated and emerge socially, culturally, and academically. Epistemological solidarity has been offered as a relational means for addressing, examining, and evaluating people's modes of existence within given subjective, inter-subjective, social, cultural, political, and environmental contexts.

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